

GLOSSARY

ADHESION

Frictional grip between the wheels of a locomotive and the rail of a track, which is affected by axle weight.

AIR BRAKE

Braking system that uses compressed air as its operating medium. While applying the brake, compressed air is released into a cylinder, pushing a piston and spring that pushes the brake block against the wheel.

ALTERNATING CURRENT (AC)

Electric current that reverses its direction of flow rapidly at regular intervals. *See also* Direct current (DC).

AQUEDUCT

Bridge built on arches with stone channels to supply water. Aqueducts source water from distant waterbodies and carry it across difficult landscapes.

AXLE

Rod that connects a pair of wheels.

BOILER

Part of the steam engine where steam is produced and circulated. The boiler must be filled with water almost to the brim. This water is generally heated to produce steam, which builds a high pressure.

BRAKE

Brakes help to slow down or halt a locomotive. They are activated by either air, steam, or a vacuum. *See also* Air brake, Vacuum brake.